



united nations relief and works agency for
palestine refugees in the near east



ANNUAL REPORT

2025

Department of Internal Oversight Services



Cover Photo :

Displaced children from Ein El-Hilweh camp seek refuge in Nablus School Emergency Shelter in Sidon, Lebanon. Photo by Maysoun Mustafa

About UNRWA

UNRWA is a United Nations agency established by the General Assembly in 1949 and mandated to provide assistance and protection to a population of over 5.7 million registered Palestine refugees. Its mission is to help Palestine refugees in Jordan, Lebanon, Syria, West Bank and the Gaza Strip achieve their full human development potential, pending a just and lasting solution to their plight. UNRWA services encompass education, health care, relief and social services, camp infrastructure and improvement, and microfinance. UNRWA is financed almost entirely by voluntary contributions.

Investigation Division

A. Overview

In 2025, the DIOS Investigations Division (ID) continued to deliver on its strategic objective, advancing its mandate to **strengthen accountability and promote neutrality**, a vital element in safeguarding donor trust. This year has seen a significant expansion of the Division's investigation function through additional resources, such as specialized support to the CIU, NIU, and SMIU units.

An institutional milestone in 2025 was the completion and roll-out of the **centralization of agency-wide complaint intake** practices. Finalized and fully operational by June 2025, this reform unified previously decentralized systems across field offices into a single, standardized Central Intake Unit at DIOS ID.

In parallel, a major milestone took place in October 2025, which was the **digitalization of the reporting and analytics function** through the launch of a departmental Power BI system developed entirely by the data and reporting unit, under DIOS ID. The recently published platform consolidates all misconduct data, neutrality, sexual misconduct, and fraud and loss to the Agency statistics and data into a single, interactive dashboard that provides real-time, automated analysis and management insights.

This digital innovation replaced labor-intensive manual analysis with automated, on-demand reporting, allowing management to access case statistics, timelines, and overall trends at the click of a button.



Figure 1: Timeline of Milestones Achieved in the Investigations Division

In 2025, DIOS ID continued with its employment of the **EU fund**, this funding enabled the division to leverage this support for key activities such as:

- Enhancement of the (NIU) capacity and efficacy with additional resources and staff.
- Finalization of the Intake Centralization Roadmap in June 2025 and provision of

additional resources such as interpreters/translators and intake assessment assistants.

- Technical training for investigators, in collaboration with the Office of Internal Oversight Services (OIOS).

Investigations Division Resources

As of December 31, 2025, DIOS ID currently has a total of 17 filled positions, including both area and international staff.

The DIOS ID consists of Area Staff posts, including 12 staff members, of which five are funded by EU Project Funds.

The Commencement of the Centralization Roadmap of Agency-Wide Complaints

The rollout of the DIOS Investigations Division's centralization roadmap reached full operational capacity in 2025, thereby completing the full centralization of the intake function. This strategy, originally built on the key pillars of development, leadership, and oversight, aimed at strengthening coordination, efficiency, and accountability across all field offices through the specialized units, the Central Intake Unit (CIU), the Neutrality Investigations Unit (NIU), and the Sexual Misconduct Investigations Unit (SMIU).

In 2025, most units have been reinforced with additional resources, including specialized personnel such as interpreters/translators and intake assessment assistants to manage high-profile and sensitive complaints. The initiative was solidified in the finalization of the Centralized Intake Unit (CIU), which was fully implemented by mid-2025. These measures managed to produce significant operational gains, achieving a **32.5%** increase in processing complaints compared with the period prior to the centralization, demonstrating the effectiveness and necessity of the centralization roadmap.

B. The Work of the Investigations Division Units

Central Intake Unit (CIU)

In 2025 the Central Intake Unit (CIU) received a total of **948** complaints through the three DIOS hotline mechanisms, an almost comparable number to last year. (2024, 993).

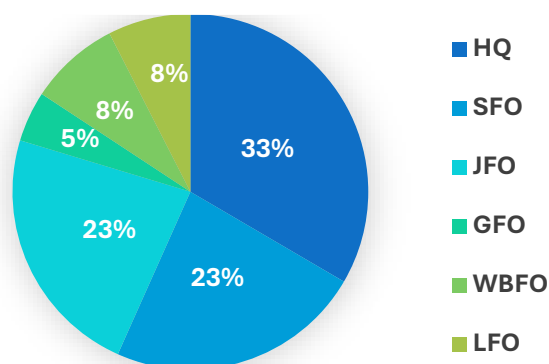
Out of the **948** complaints, a total of **718** complaints containing **863** allegations of misconduct were assessed and presented at Intake Committee Meetings (IC). As for the other 230 complaints received, they did not include any allegations of

misconduct and were either requests, inquiries or suggestions.

Even though the number of complaints received last year was slightly higher, the number of complaints received and assessed in 2025 was 1.5 times higher than the number of complaints assessed in 2024, representing the highest number of complaints assessed in the past five years, due to the intense and efficient workload of the centralized intake unit, following the centralization.

Out of the 718 complaints received and assessed, DIOS ID directly handled **240** complaints, including **40** breaches of neutrality allegations and **34** complaints of sexual misconduct.

Figure 2: Percentage of Complaints Assessed by Field Office



Moreover, DIOS ID conducted **58** centralized IC meetings and facilitated **73** decentralized and centralized IC meetings across the five field offices as follows: JFO 19, SFO 19, GFO 7, WBFO 15 and LFO 13, where complaints were assessed, discussed and then presented accordingly in the above pie chart.

This follows the last phase of the centralization of the intake process that was finalised in June 2025, as the **CIU currently handles the entire complaint-intake process.**

Neutrality Investigations Unit (NIU)

The Neutrality Investigations Unit (NIU) had been operating with only two personnel staff members on temporary project-funded contracts for the most part of 2024.

To address this critical understaffing, DIOS ID appointed additional personnel during 2025 to support NIU operations, which includes a translator to assist with the transcription and translation of the numerous investigative interviews as well as an intake assessment assistant to help manage the volume of incoming allegations.

In a key development, NIU collaborated with the Humanitarian Principles Unit to establish a consolidated case management system. This system is designed to centralize all received neutrality breach allegations, enhancing the tracking and reporting on such cases.

Additionally, NIU is nearing the completion of the acquisition of computer forensics and online investigations, both hardware and software to enhance investigation capacity.

Based on the earlier roadmap for centralizing the investigation of neutrality-related allegations within DIOS, The NIU reviews all neutrality breaches received Agency-wide, ranging from minor infractions to severe ones like involvement in military and political groups. After review, NIU prepares a formal intake assessment and presents it to a DIOS ID-Centralized Intake committee for deliberation on neutrality breach allegations.

Figure 3: Process of Reviewing Neutrality Allegations.

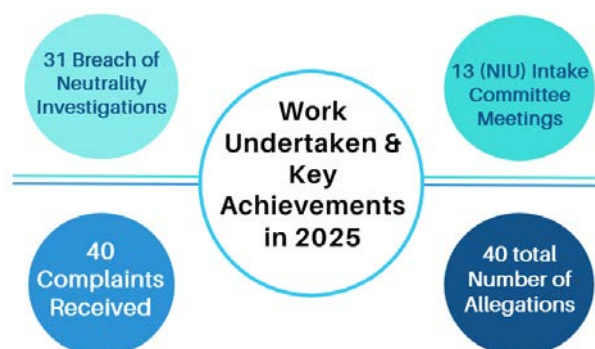


The diagram on the right provides an overview of the work and achievements of the NIU in 2025.

A total **13** formal intake committee meetings were conducted in 2025 which discussed the 40 complaints received, addressing allegations that staff had breached the principle of neutrality. The nature of allegations ranged from posting inappropriate content on social media platforms to alleged involvement in militant activities, actions considered serious violations of UNRWA's neutrality standards.

Out of the **40** assessments carried out, **31** investigations were authorized. For the remaining cases, alternative actions were taken, for example referral to UNRWA Legal Offices for cases involving daily paid personnel, in accordance with applicable policy.

During 2025, NIU completed **22** cases of neutrality cases, with **13** allegations substantiated.



Colonna Report and implications for Neutrality

Following the Action Plan initiated by UNRWA in response to the 50 recommendations issued by the Colonna Review, DIOS ID expanded its field presence and oversight capacity and made steady progress in implementing several measures that were scheduled for 2025 under its wider centralization roadmap.

In addition, DIOS ID finalized the preparations to deploy three senior investigators from Headquarters to selected field offices. One has already been deployed in the Syria Field Office and the other two will be deployed by the second quarter of 2026.

Figure 4: The Work of the NIU and Key Achievements

The Division also continued the direct support and oversight of field investigation leads through the Senior Field Office Investigations Officer.

The division's Neutrality Investigations Unit (NIU), continued to build its staffing and operational capacity as the centralization of the complaint intake process was being finalized this year.

At the same time, the investigation policy went through amendments to target the focus of the investigation resources on credible and verifiable complaints only.

Moreover, an approval for an **External Review of the Investigation Function** was secured, with the revised Terms of Reference signed on 10 April 2025. These actions demonstrate DIOS ID commitment to implementing the recommendations of the independent review and further strengthening its investigative neutrality framework.

Sexual Misconduct Investigations Unit

The Sexual Misconduct Investigation Unit (SMIU) is a specialized unit within DIOS ID, mandated to receive, assess, and investigate allegations of sexual exploitation, abuse, and harassment within the Agency. Operating with strict confidentiality,

SMIU ensures timely, survivor-centered, and trauma-informed investigations. SMIU collaborates closely with prevention, protection and safeguarding teams to ensure that victims have access to psychosocial, medical, and legal support services, safeguarding their safety and well-being throughout the investigative process.

In 2025, the SMIU expanded its capacity, growing from two investigators to a dedicated team of four staff members. This strategic reinforcement enabled SMIU to respond more promptly to allegations, reduce case backlogs, and significantly shorten the average time to complete investigations.

Figure 5: SMIU Complaints Received in 2025 by Intake Decision

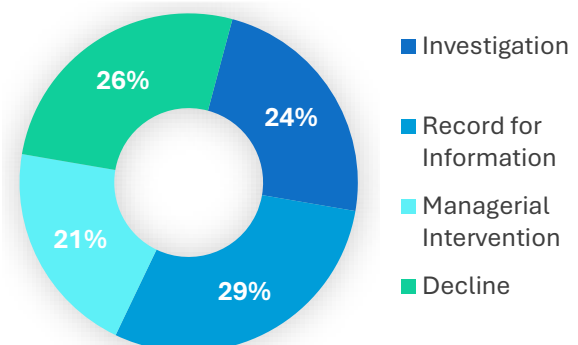
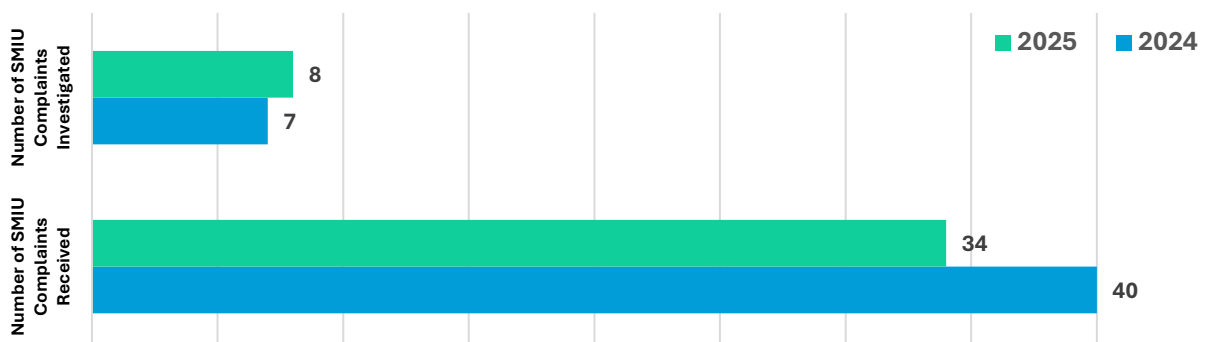


Figure 6. SMIU Complaints Received and Investigated (2024-2025)



In 2025, SMIU recorded a decrease in reported complaints, with 34 complaints reported, compared to 40 complaints in 2024. This decrease is largely due to a number of reasons, such as potential for underreporting due to fear, stigma, or limited access to reporting channels.

Moreover, the current situation in the territories where UNRWA operates, namely in Gaza and West Bank, are not conducive to reporting sexual misconduct (heightened barriers to disclosure,

including insecurity, stigma, and lack of access to reporting mechanisms).

As for investigated cases, eight cases were predicated for investigation in 2025 as opposed to seven in 2024. This is due to a combination of strengthened investigative measures including an increase in the number of credible and substantiated allegations as well as enhanced oversight, and accountability mechanisms.

C. Key Activities

Investigations managed by the DIOS Investigation Division

Throughout 2025, DIOS ID saw a major increase in the number of investigations initiated, compared to the previous year. This spike is due to the increased influx of complaints received and the largely enhanced capacity of complaints intake by the CIU, hence, higher number of evidence-based complaints advancing to the investigation stage.

Moreover, the CIU received a complaint containing 468 beneficiaries who intelligibly received cash assistance. Out of the 468 beneficiaries, 16 active fixed-term staff were investigated since they received over \$1,000 in assistance.

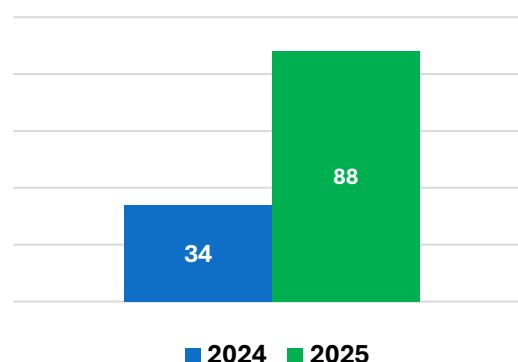
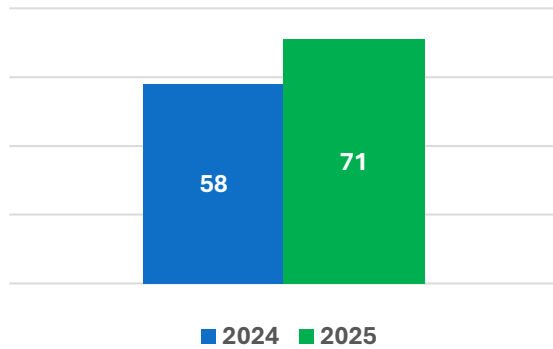


Figure 7. Number of Cases Opened by DIOS ID

On the other hand, DIOS ID managed to close 71 serious and/or complex investigations (involving 81 misconduct allegations) in 2025, these include cases that were carried over from previous years in addition to the newly opened cases in 2025. This number represents a noticeable increase compared to the number of cases closed in 2024, due to the significant efforts of the DIOS ID investigators for this year.

Figure 8: Number of Cases Closed by DIOS ID



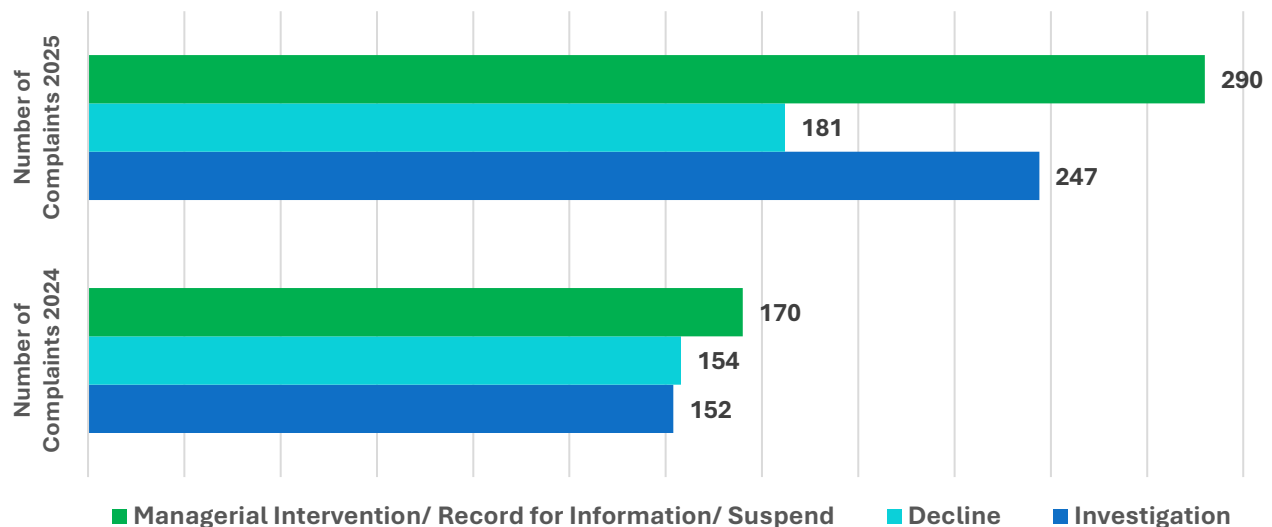
Out of the **718** complaints assessed, **34%** deemed to warrant an investigation, a slight decrease from 35% in 2024. The decrease is a reflection of the triage system the CIU functions by, which includes enhanced and thorough assessments aiming to ensure that only credible and verifiable allegations advance to the investigation phase.

This enhanced process led to more referrals of performance-related complaints for managerial oversight, enabling investigators to focus on higher-priority cases of misconduct.

Agency-wide Investigation activities

In 2025, DIOS ID assessed and facilitated the assessment of **718** complaints containing **863** allegations of misconduct.

Figure 9. Number of Total Complaints Received and Assessed by the Intake Committee's Decision (2024 and 2025).



In 2025, the Director of DIOS along with field directors approved 34% of cases for immediate investigation compared to 31% in 2024. Additionally, 25% of complaints were declined as they were deemed to lack any corroborating evidence, a substantial decrease from 31% in 2024. This is due to the efforts of CIU ensuring that only

credible allegations proceed to investigation and referring non-misconduct-related complaints to managerial oversight responsibility. The remaining 40% of complaints were recorded for information, referred to managerial intervention, or suspended pending further information and evidence.

Analysis of Investigation Cases in 2025

The table below provides a detailed breakdown of cases handled in 2025, based on allegation type, and covers cases previously opened (still under investigation), recently opened, as well as all cases closed in 2025.

Figure 10 - Agency-Wide Cases in 2025 (including cases handled by DIOS ID).

UNRWA	Total Number	Breach of Neutrality	Sexual Exploitation and Abuse	Sexual Harassment	Failure to Comply with Professional Standards	Fraud, Theft and Loss to the Agency	Harassment, Discrimination and Abuse of Authority	Assault (Not CP)	Retaliation	Recruitment Irregularities	Corporal Punishment	Other Misconduct
Previously Open Cases	189	11	4	2	30	39	25	9	1	5	48	15
Cases Opened	247	31	4	3	26	71	33	4	0	0	58	17
Cases Closed	279	22	6	4	37	62	37	5	1	5	77	23
Currently Open Cases	159	20	3	1	19	48	21	8	0	0	30	9

- In 2025, **189** cases were carried over from previous years and **247** cases warranted investigation.
- Fraud, theft and loss to agency cases were the highest in 2025, out of which 16 cases were investigated under DIOS ID, due to the complaint that the CIU received, which stated that 19 staff members had mistakenly received cash assistance, equal to or exceeding \$1,000 each.
- Corporal punishment had a slight increase from last year, as the number still stood at **58** opened cases. This is due to an emerging influx in the number of cases coming from JFO, as well as the high number of cases coming from SFO. Even with the use of managerial intervention to address parts of corporal punishment allegations.
- Breach of neutrality cases experienced an increase from 2024, due to the majority of allegations being reported in 2023, following the onset of the conflict in Gaza.
- Harassment, discrimination, and abuse of authority cases had a notable rise. The rise is due to DIOS ID's support in helping field offices accurately categorize complaints during IC meetings.
- Assault (Not CP) cases showed a major decrease in 2025, which was influenced by enhanced code of conduct and remote work policies in WBFO, GFO, and LFO.

By the end of 2025, only **159** cases remained open, reflecting the persistent efforts to resolve issues. It is also worth noting that this number is the lowest number of cases carried over from previous years, in the past four years.

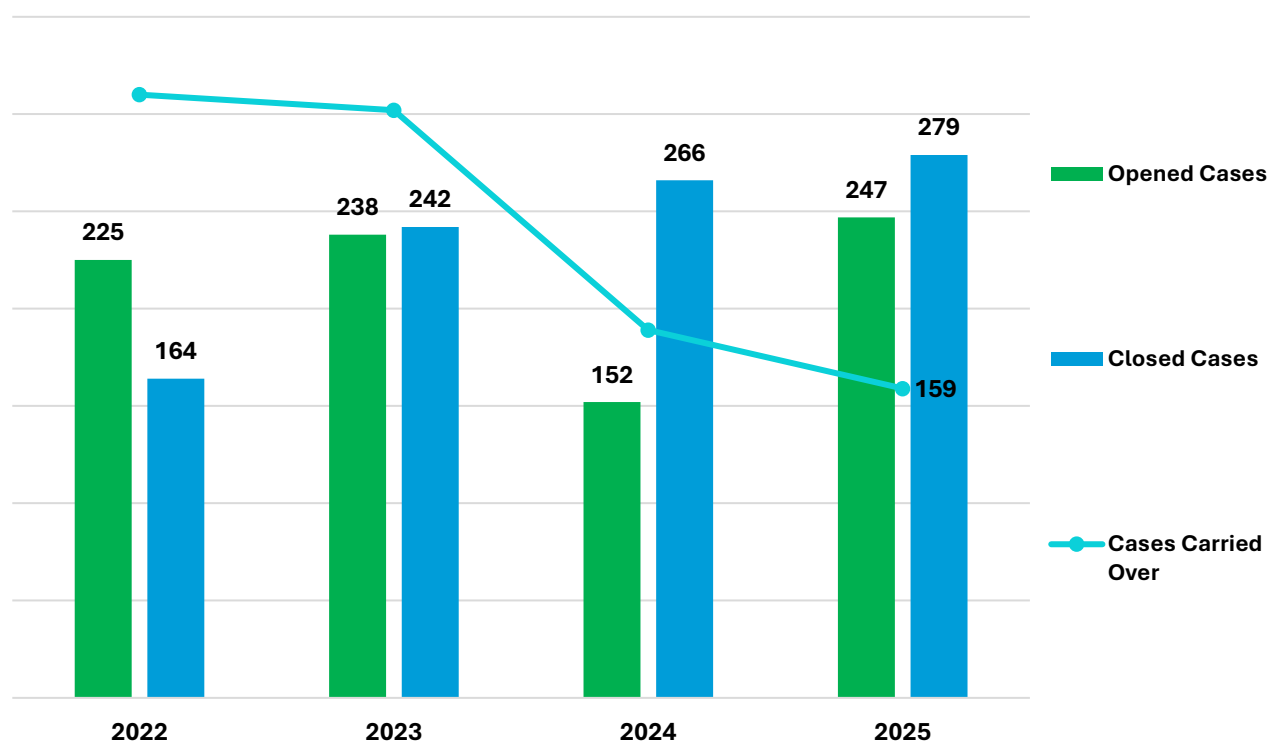
Mega Trend Analysis of UNRWA Cases

The following chart illustrates the trends of agency-wide investigation cases from 2022 to 2025. In 2025 DIOS ID recorded a clear increase in the number of opened cases compared to 2024. This is due to the increased assessment capacity of the CIU, operating based on credibility and verifiability alongside an optimized resource allocation within the division. Basically, higher complaint intake led to higher assessed complaints, and eventually higher investigation count, where complaints warranted investigation. 2025 marked a significant turning point in case status outcomes, through an increased focus on the monitoring of case

progression, and enhanced prioritization protocols.

The DIOS ID managed to substantially increase the volume of cases closed while ensuring the quality of the investigation process. These measures led to the full closure of all investigation cases, opened prior to 2025. With the exception of GFO cases, no cases from previous years remain open by the end of the reporting period of 2025. This achievement reflects the lowest case backlog recorded in at least the past four years and established a reset baseline for future reporting cycles in 2026 onwards.

Figure 11: A Column and Line Chart Showing the Trend of Opened, Closed and Previously Opened Cases from 2022 to 2025



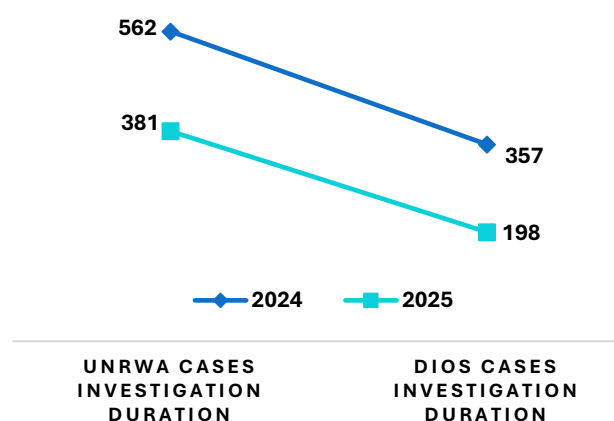
Performance Indicators

In 2025, DIOS ID continued to prioritize clearing the investigation backlog in all field offices, managing to eradicate all cases dating back to 2023 and 2024.

These efforts are reflected in the decrease of the investigation duration until closure, while still managing to achieve ~70% of the 290-day target. As for UNRWA's investigation duration timeline, the overall case completion time shot down this year to 382 days as opposed to 562 days last year (34% improvement).

This is mostly due to the incredible work of the central intake unit in regard to faster complaints processing, having significantly increased their capacity of complaints intake and assessment, proving the result of their achievements with their work in resolving complaints in less than 2.5 months in comparison with 4 months in 2024. The improvement was even greater for the cases investigated by DIOS Headquarters, reaching 45% improvement or 6.6 months on average for completion of an investigation.

Figure 12: A Line Chart Showing a Comparison Between Performance Indicators in 2024 and 2025.



D. DIOS ID Support to Field Offices

The Senior Field Office Investigations Officer (SFOIO) continued to provide direct support to all field investigations to strengthen oversight and mitigate risks. This arrangement has been in place for years, replacing the previous reporting line to field directors and has enhanced the functional independence of investigators in the field.

In 2025, the Centralized Intake Unit (CIU) became fully operational following the finalization of the centralization and currently manages all intake processes for the agency through the triage processes, ensuring the handling of complaints, especially those involving high-risk allegations.

Challenges and Justifications

In 2025, DIOS prioritized resolving GFO cases that were carried over from as early as 2021, this was due to persistent challenges such as limited access and communication barriers under the ongoing political situation which delayed the closure of such cases.

Through targeted support ID managed to successfully close 20 cases with comprehensive closure reports submitted. DIOS ID also plans to continue enhancing performance indicators to improve efficiency and shorten processing times.

While there have been many achievements and improvements in multiple areas within the division, several challenges remain persistent that require attention to ensure the continued success of DIOS ID's operations. Due to the implementation of the Colonna report as well as increased workload because of neutrality allegations, a number of challenges came about, hence DIOS ID will move forward with structured support to ensure consistency and quality across field offices.

Challenges	DIOS ID Justification
Security and Access Restrictions	Persistent political instability limits site access and witnesses' mobility, investigations are delayed by transportation/telecom problems, and the credibility of evidence is impacted by remote interviews.
Limited Capacity to Offer Victim Protection, Support, and Assistance	UNRWA's ability to protect victims is limited, particularly in areas affected by conflict like Gaza and Lebanon.
Criminal Allegations and Gaps	DIOS ID is largely dependent on host countries for incomplete information and lacks its own intelligence-gathering capabilities, which affects the comprehensiveness of investigations.



E. Way Forward (2026 and beyond)

In 2026, DIOS ID will continue building the trust of stakeholders by focusing on specific, measurable initiatives:

- Enhancing the intake process to continue prioritizing backlog cases and strategically target investigation duration reduction. This could be achieved by amending the policy to focus only on credible, verifiable, and sufficiently backed-up allegations (Target: Q2/2026).
- second assessing investigative quality in all field offices and headquarters, third, pinpointing systematic improvements required for strengthening the division's effectiveness.

- The DIOS ID is set to finalize its digital transformation, centered on the Case Management System (CMS) to obtain secure storage as well as audit trails. Moreover, the full development and publishing of a Real-Time Tracking Power BI dashboard for integrity and transparency has been in progress for six months in 2025 and will be formalized in 2026.

DIOS ID aims to complete investigations for DIOS ID at HQ(A) as well as field investigations within six months' time (Target: End of 2026).

An initiation of an External Review of the Investigation Function in order to provide valuable external perspective to the Agency, will take place in Q1 and Q2 of 2026.

The final report will include findings, a feasibility assessment, and a transition roadmap. The review will work on three main areas, first, compliance with UN Uniform Guidelines for Investigations.

Figure 13: A Flowchart Showing Stages of the External Review of the Investigation Function 2025 report



Strengthening Oversight Through Digital Transformation and Data Analytics

In 2025, the investigations division achieved a historical milestone in its commitment to transparency and operational excellence through the initiation and development of a full-scale Power BI Reporting and Analytics System.

This was solely developed by the reporting and data unit since the division decided to move beyond manual reporting to a dynamic, real-time reporting framework. This transition is not just a technical upgrade but a strategic cornerstone building on data-driven transparency and accountability, allowing for a clear understanding of the Agency's misconduct framework across all field offices.

The core of this initiative is a multi-layered dashboard designed to track the lifecycle of a complaint, from the date of receiving the complaint to intake decision and finally the closure of an investigation for complaints predicated for investigation.

DIOS ID can now balance transparency with confidentiality through the mechanisms of such reporting system; this ensures that integrity and professionalism are not compromised as visibility increases.

Some noteworthy points of this system were reflected in the ability to constantly view vital KPIs such as time spent until intake decision was made against a complaint and time spent by investigators on closing an investigation.

In addition, you can view live classification of allegations, particularly high-priority allegations of misconduct, including Breach of Neutrality, Sexual Exploitation and Abuse (SEA), Sexual Harassment, Fraud, Theft and Loss to the Agency, and Corporal Punishment. Providing immediate statistics and data and ensuring these allegations receive the highest priority and resources.

A pie chart was incorporated that provides a geographical distribution that shows the number of complaints and allegations received per field office, with the relevant allegations based on category as well as the KPIs measuring timelines of intake decision and case closure.

Through the additional filter of "Intake Decision", it provides a more surgical view on the type of allegations received by intake decision following intake committee meetings ensuring that every complaint of misconduct is met with a visible proportionate and documented response, hence reinforcing accountability and transparency across the Agency's digital footprint.